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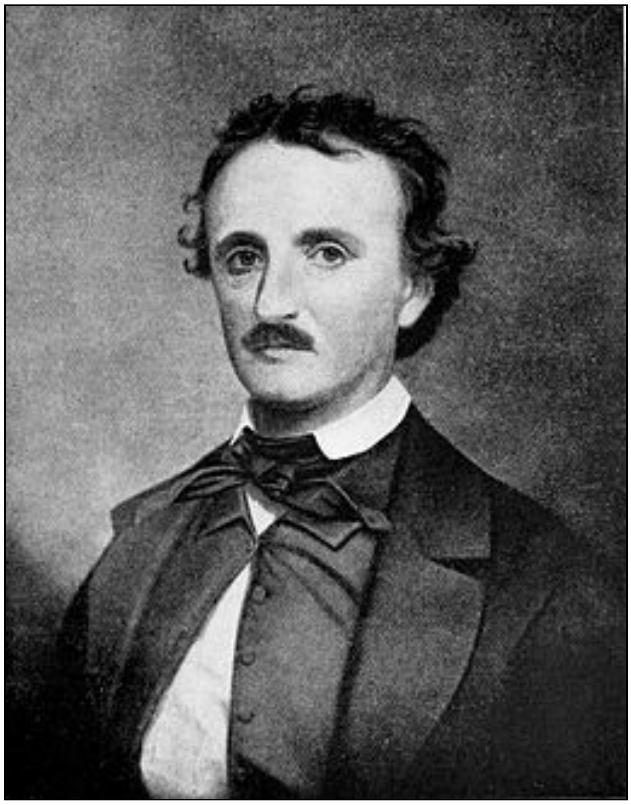
The Tell-Tale Heart

By Edgar Allan Poe
1843

Edgar Allan Poe (1809-1849) was an American poet and author who often wrote tales of horror that gave insight into the human condition. Published in 1843, "The Tell-Tale Heart" is a retelling of murder and madness, and is considered a classic of American literature. As you read, think critically about the narrator of this story, taking notes on his point of view and motivations.

[1] TRUE!—nervous—very, very dreadfully nervous I had been and am; but why will you say that I am mad? The disease had sharpened my senses—not destroyed—not dulled them. Above all was the sense of hearing acute. I heard all things in the heaven and in the earth. I heard many things in hell. How, then, am I mad? Hearken! and observe how healthily—how calmly I can tell you the whole story.

It is impossible to say how first the idea entered my brain; but once conceived, it haunted me day and night. Object there was none. Passion there was none. I loved the old man. He had never wronged me. He had never given me insult. For his gold I had no desire. I think it was his eye! yes, it was this! One of his eyes resembled that of a vulture—a pale blue eye, with a film over it. Whenever it fell upon me, my blood ran cold; and so by degrees—very gradually—I made up my mind to take the life of the old man, and thus rid myself of the eye for ever.



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Now this is the point. You fancy me mad. Madmen know nothing. But you should have seen me. You should have seen how wisely I proceeded—with what caution— with what foresight—with what dissimulation[1] I went to work! I was never kinder to the old man than during the whole week before I killed him. And every night, about midnight, I turned the latch of his door and opened it—oh, so gently! And then, when I had made an opening sufficient for my head, I put in a dark lantern, all closed, closed, so that no light shone out, and then I thrust in my head. Oh, you would have laughed to see how cunningly I thrust it in! I moved it slowly—very, very slowly, so that I might not disturb the old man's sleep. It took me an hour to place my whole head within the opening so far that I could see him as he lay upon his bed. Ha!—would a madman have been so wise as this? And then, when my head was well in the room, I undid the lantern cautiously—oh, so cautiously—cautiously (for the hinges creaked)—I undid it just so much that a single thin ray fell upon the vulture eye. And this I did for seven long nights—every night just at midnight—but I found the eye always closed; and so it was impossible to do the work; for it was not the old man who vexed me, but his Evil Eye. And every morning, when the day broke, I went boldly into the chamber, and spoke courageously to him, calling him by name in a hearty tone, and inquiring how he had passed the night. So you see he would have been a very profound old man, indeed, to suspect that every night, just at twelve, I looked in upon him while he slept.

Upon the eighth night I was more than usually cautious in opening the door. A watch's minute hand moves more quickly than did mine. Never before that night had I felt the extent of my own powers—of my sagacity.[2] I could scarcely contain my feelings of triumph. To think that there I was, opening the door, little by little, and he not even to dream of my secret deeds or thoughts. I fairly chuckled at the idea; and perhaps he heard me; for he moved on the bed suddenly, as if startled. Now you may think that I drew back—but no. His room was as black as pitch with the thick darkness (for the shutters were close fastened, through fear of robbers), and so I knew that he could not see the opening of the door, and I kept pushing it on steadily, steadily.

[5] I had my head in, and was about to open the lantern, when my thumb slipped upon the tin fastening, and the old man sprang up in the bed, crying out—"Who's there?"

I kept quite still and said nothing. For a whole hour I did not move a muscle, and in the meantime I did not hear him lie down. He was still sitting up in the bed listening;—just as I have done, night after night, hearkening to the death watches in the wall.

Presently I heard a slight groan, and I knew it was the groan of mortal terror. It was not a groan of pain or of grief—oh, no!—it was the low stifled sound that arises from the bottom of the soul when overcharged with awe. I knew the sound well. Many a night, just at midnight, when all the world slept, it has welled up from my own bosom, deepening, with its dreadful echo, the terrors that distracted me. I say I knew it well. I knew what the old man felt, and pitied him, although I chuckled at heart. I knew that he had been lying awake ever since the first slight noise, when he had turned in the bed. His fears had been ever since growing upon him. He had been trying to fancy them causeless, but could not. He had been saying to himself—"It is nothing but the wind in the chimney—it is only a mouse crossing the floor," or "it is merely a cricket which has made a single chirp." Yes, he has been trying to comfort himself with these suppositions; but he had found all in vain. All in vain; because Death, in approaching him, had stalked with his black shadow before him, and enveloped the victim. And it was the mournful influence of the unperceived shadow that caused him to feel—although he neither saw nor heard—to feel the presence of my head within the room.

1. **Dissimulation** ***(noun):*** concealment of one's thoughts, feelings, or character; deceit
2. **Sagacity** ***(noun):*** keen judgement; knowledge or wisdom

When I had waited a long time, very patiently, without hearing him lie down, I resolved to open a little—a very, very little crevice in the lantern. So I opened it—you cannot imagine how stealthily, stealthily—until, at length, a single dim ray, like the thread of the spider, shot from out the crevice and full upon the vulture eye.

It was open—wide, wide open—and I grew furious as I gazed upon it. I saw it with perfect distinctness—all a dull blue, with a hideous veil over it that chilled the very marrow in my bones; but I could see nothing else of the old man's face or person: for I had directed the ray as if by instinct, precisely upon the damned spot.

[10] And now have I not told you that what you mistake for madness is but over-acuteness of the senses?—now, I say, there came to my ears a low, dull, quick sound, such as a watch makes when enveloped in cotton. I knew that sound well too. It was the beating of the old man's heart. It increased my fury, as the beating of a drum stimulates the soldier into courage.

But even yet I refrained and kept still. I scarcely breathed. I held the lantern motionless. I tried how steadily I could maintain the ray upon the eye. Meantime the hellish tattoo[3] of the heart increased. It grew quicker and quicker, and louder and louder every instant. The old man's terror must have been extreme! It grew louder, I say, louder every moment!—do you mark me well? I have told you that I am nervous: so I am. And now at the dead hour of the night, amid the dreadful silence of that old house, so strange a noise as this excited me to uncontrollable terror. Yet, for some minutes longer I refrained and stood still. But the beating grew louder, louder! I thought the heart must burst. And now a new anxiety seized me—the sound would be heard by a neighbor! The old man's hour had come! With a loud yell, I threw open the lantern and leaped into the room. He shrieked once—once only. In an instant I dragged him to the floor, and pulled the heavy bed over him. I then smiled gaily, to find the deed so far done. But, for many minutes, the heart beat on with a muffled sound. This, however, did not vex me; it would not be heard through the wall. At length it ceased. The old man was dead. I removed the bed and examined the corpse. Yes, he was stone, stone dead. I placed my hand upon the heart and held it there many minutes. There was no pulsation. He was stone dead. His eye would trouble me no more.

If still you think me mad, you will think so no longer when I describe the wise precautions I took for the concealment of the body. The night waned, and I worked hastily, but in silence. First of all I dismembered the corpse. I cut off the head and the arms and the legs.

I then took up three planks from the flooring of the chamber, and deposited all between the scantlings.[4] I then replaced the boards so cleverly, so cunningly, that no human eye—not even his—could have detected any thing wrong. There was nothing to wash out—no stain of any kind—no blood-spot whatever. I had been too wary for that. A tub had caught all—ha! ha!

When I had made an end of these labors, it was four o'clock—still dark as midnight. As the bell sounded the hour, there came a knocking at the street door. I went down to open it with a light heart,—for what had I now to fear? There entered three men, who introduced themselves, with perfect suavity, as officers of the police. A shriek had been heard by a neighbor during the night; suspicion of foul play had been aroused; information had been lodged at the police office, and they (the officers) had been deputed to search the premises.

3. **Tattoo** ***(noun):*** a rhythmic tapping or drumming beat
4. **Scantlings** ***(noun):*** a piece of lumber of small cross section

[15] I smiled,—for what had I to fear? I bade the gentlemen welcome. The shriek, I said, was my own in a dream. The old man, I mentioned, was absent in the country. I took my visitors all over the house. I bade them search—search well. I led them, at length, to his chamber. I showed them his treasures, secure, undisturbed. In the enthusiasm of my confidence, I brought chairs into the room, and desired them here to rest from their fatigues, while I myself, in the wild audacity[5] of my perfect triumph, placed my own seat upon the very spot beneath which reposed the corpse of the victim.

The officers were satisfied. My manner had convinced them. I was singularly at ease. They sat, and while I answered cheerily, they chatted of familiar things. But, ere long, I felt myself getting pale and wished them gone. My head ached, and I fancied a ringing in my ears: but still they sat and still chatted. The ringing became more distinct:—it continued and became more distinct: I talked more freely to get rid of the feeling: but it continued and gained definitiveness—until, at length, I found that the noise was not within my ears.

No doubt I now grew very pale;—but I talked more fluently, and with a heightened voice. Yet the sound increased—and what could I do? It was a low, dull, quick sound—much such a sound as a watch makes when enveloped in cotton. I gasped for breath—and yet the officers heard it not. I talked more quickly—more vehemently;[6] but the noise steadily increased. I arose and argued about trifles, in a high key and with violent gesticulations, but the noise steadily increased. Why would they not be gone? I paced the floor to and fro with heavy strides, as if excited to fury by the observation of the men—but the noise steadily increased. Oh God! what could I do? I foamed—I raved—I swore! I swung the chair upon which I had been sitting, and grated it upon the boards, but the noise arose over all and continually increased. It grew louder—louder—louder! And still the men chatted pleasantly, and smiled. Was it possible they heard not? Almighty God!—no, no! They heard!—they suspected!—they knew!—they were making a mockery of my horror!—this I thought, and this I think. But any thing was better than this agony! Any thing was more tolerable than this derision! I could bear those hypocritical smiles no longer! I felt that I must scream or die!—and now—again!— hark! louder! louder! louder! louder!—

“Villains!” I shrieked, “dissemble no more! I admit the deed!—tear up the planks!—here, here!—it is the beating of his hideous heart!”

The Tell-Tale Heart by Edgar Allan Poe is in the public domain.

5. **Audacity** ***(noun):*** boldness, daring
6. **Vehemently** ***(adverb):*** forcefully or strongly with emotion

Text-Dependent Questions

Directions: For the following questions, choose the best answer or respond in complete sentences.

1. PART A: Which of the following best identifies the major themes of the story? [RL.2]
    A. Morality and justice
    B. Guilt and conscience
    C. Prejudice and fear
    D. Truth and perception

2. PART B: Which of the following quotes provides the best support for the answer to Part A? [RL.1]
    A. “Whenever it fell upon me, my blood ran cold; and so by degrees—very gradually—I made up my mind to take the life of the old man, and thus rid myself of the eye for ever.” (Paragraph 2)
    B. “Yes, he has been trying to comfort himself with these suppositions; but he had found all in vain. All in vain; because Death, in approaching him, had stalked with his black shadow before him, and enveloped the victim.” (Paragraph 7)
    C. "As the bell sounded the hour, there came a knocking at the street door. I went down to open it with a light heart,—for what had I now to fear?” (Paragraph 14)
    D. "'I admit the deed!—tear up the planks!—here, here!—it is the beating of his hideous heart!'" (Paragraph 18)

3. PART A: Which of the following finally drives the narrator to murder the old man? [RL.3]
    A. The old man’s blue eye
    B. The sound of a heart beating beneath the floorboards
    C. The narrator’s unstable mental health
    D. The narrator’s sensitive hearing exacerbated by the old man’s heartbeat

4. PART B: Which of the following quotations provides the best support for the answer to Part A? [RL.1]
    A. "The disease had sharpened my senses—not destroyed—not dulled them. Above all was the sense of hearing acute. I heard all things in the heaven and in the earth. I heard many things in hell." (Paragraph 1)
    B. "One of his eyes resembled that of a vulture—a pale blue eye, with a film over it. Whenever it fell upon me, my blood ran cold" (Paragraph 2)
    C. "But the beating grew louder, louder! I thought the heart must burst. And now a new anxiety seized me—the sound would be heard by a neighbor! The old man’s hour had come!" (Paragraph 11)
    D. "the noise steadily increased. Oh God! what could I do? I foamed—I raved—I swore!" (Paragraph 17)

5. Which of the following best describes the figurative significance of the beating heart? [RL.4]

   A. It represents the narrator's own death drawing near as he faces punishment for his crime.
   B. It is a supernatural punishment for the narrator's crime.
   C. It represents the narrator's guilt over murdering the old man, for he mistakes his own heartbeat for the old man's.
   D. It signifies his increasing madness and dwindling control over himself.

6. Compare and contrast the narrator's point of view at the beginning to the end of the story. Note any differences and the possible causes behind these differences. [RL.6] [RL.3]

Discussion Questions

Directions: Brainstorm your answers to the following questions in the space provided. Be prepared to share your original ideas in a class discussion.

1. The narrator claims he is not mad—do you believe him? What constitutes madness? Cite evidence in your answer that either supports or disproves this claim.

2. How does fear drive action? What does the narrator fear and why? Use evidence from this text, your own experience, and other art, literature or history in your answer.

For Teachers

Suggested Text Pairings

The Cask of Amontillado by Edgar Allan Poe **Short Story**

Edgar Allan Poe's "The Cask of Amontillado" (1846) is a suspenseful short story told from the perspective of a murder. This story is a great way to introduce the concept of unreliable narrators, point of view (generally), and suspense as a literary device. Pair "The Tell-Tale Heart" with "The Cask of Amontillado" and ask student to analyze and compare these two Poe short stories, both told from the perspective of a murderer.

Stress for Success by Alison Pearce Stevens **Informational Text**

In this article, *Science News for Students* explores the ways that stress can be both harmful and helpful in our daily lives. Pair "The Tell-Tale Heart" with "Stress for Success" and ask students to consider how Poe uses fiction to bring the powerful emotion of fear to life. According to Poe, is stress more harmful or beneficial? How does the science in "Stress for Success" help support the themes of "The Tell-Tale Heart"?

The Pit and the Pendulum by Edgar Allan Poe **Short Story**

In this classic example of Poe suspense, an unnamed narrator describes the torments endured as a prisoner of the Spanish Inquisition. Pair "The Tell-Tale Heart" with "The Pit and the Pendulum" and ask students to compare these texts by the same author. Are there similar themes or devices used?

The Complexity of Fear by Mary C. Lamia, Ph.D. **Informational Text**

In this heavily researched article, Dr. Mary C. Lamia delineates between anxiety and fear, and explains why fear is such a complex emotion to understand. This tale is often considered one of the greatest stories about the power of fear. But is it really about fear? After reading "The Complexity of Fear," challenge students to analyze the emotions felt by the narrator of this story. Was he driven by fear, or anxiety? How do you know?

Answers to Text-Dependent Questions

1. B
2. E
3. D
4. C
5. C

6. Answers will vary; students should analyze the narrator's point of view at the beginning of the story (notably, his use of tone and his claims) versus his point of view at the end of the story. One of the major differences is the distress the latter is clearly expressing in his story, as well as fear and general volatile emotion. While the speaker at the beginning is "nervous—very, very dreadfully nervous" (paragraph 1) and makes wild claims about hearing all of heaven and earth, he is still far more comprehensible and controlled than the narrator at the end of the story. Likewise, the narrator's phrasing at the story's conclusion is more disjointed, erratic. The speaker at the end of the story ultimately fails to uphold his previous promise to remain calm in his retelling, undermining his assurance that he is not mad. Thus, reflecting the narrator's mental state, the speaker's point of view unravels over the course of the story.